



PC4x4SAR | Ten Essentials Checklist

piercecounty4x4sar.org | Download full guide at piercecounty4x4sar.org/safety

EMERGENCY

CALL 911

THE TEN ESSENTIAL SYSTEMS

- ❑ **1. Navigation** Map, compass, GPS/phone with offline maps
- ❑ **2. Headlamp** LED headlamp + extra batteries
- ❑ **3. Sun Protection** SPF 30+ sunscreen, sunglasses, hat, lip balm
- ❑ **4. First Aid Kit** Bandages, gauze, tape, pain meds, blister care
- ❑ **5. Knife + Repair** Multi-tool, duct tape, cord, zip ties
- ❑ **6. Fire** Waterproof matches + lighter + fire starter
- ❑ **7. Shelter** Emergency bivy, space blanket, or ultralight tarp
- ❑ **8. Extra Food** 1 extra day minimum -- bars, nuts, jerky
- ❑ **9. Extra Water** 1L extra + purification method (filter/tablets)
- ❑ **10. Extra Clothing** Insulating layer, rain gear, warm hat, gloves

FIELD TIPS

- ❑ **Keep it packed:** Store your Ten Essentials in a dedicated bag that's always ready. Grab and go.
- ❑ **Total weight:** A complete kit weighs only 3-5 lbs. There is no excuse to skip it.
- ❑ **Cotton kills:** Avoid cotton clothing -- it loses all insulation when wet. Use wool or synthetic.
- ❑ **Check dates:** Inspect expiration dates on first aid supplies, sunscreen, and water treatment every season.
- ❑ **Cold batteries:** Lithium batteries lose 20-40% capacity in cold. Keep phone/headlamp in inside pockets.
- ❑ **Water matters:** Pre-hydrate before hiking. Drink before you're thirsty. Dark urine = already dehydrated.

PIERCE COUNTY ELEVATION WARNING

Our terrain spans from sea level to 14,411 ft (Mt. Rainier). You can start at 50 deg F at the trailhead and encounter 25 deg F with wind chill at the summit. Always prepare for the highest point on your route.

MOST RESCUES INVOLVE DAY HIKERS

The majority of people we rescue planned to be out for 'just a few hours.' Afternoon weather, a wrong turn, or a minor injury can turn a short hike into an overnight. Always pack as if you might spend the night out.